

Session 32: The New Household Code

Key Takeaways

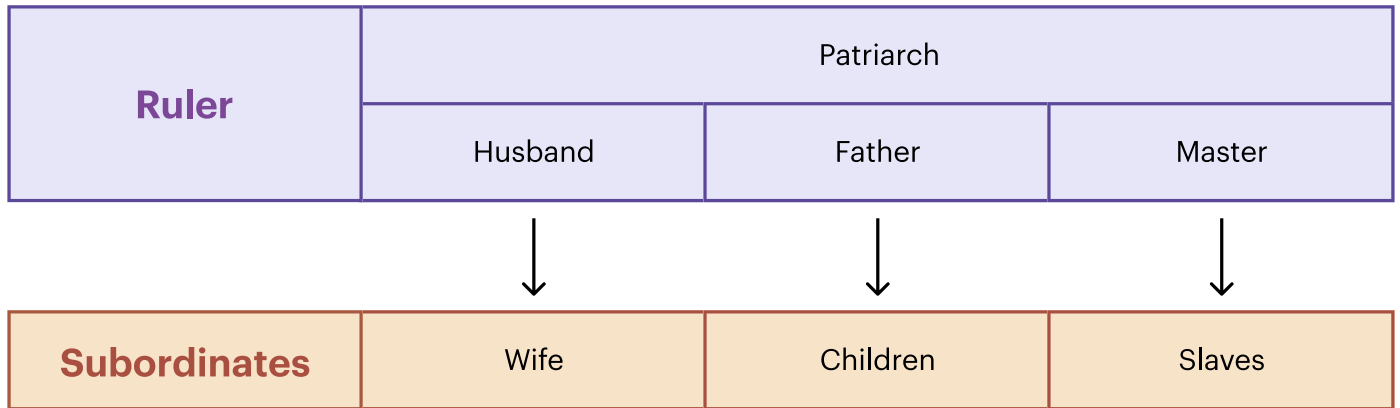
- Mutual submission is a marker of a Spirit-filled community.
- Ephesians 5:21-6:9 fits the literary form of a well-known Greco-Roman tradition called a household code, where a patriarch is informed of his responsibility to order his household as a miniature Roman Empire.
- By speaking directly to wives, children, and slaves, Paul is giving them a level of status and dignity they did not possess in their own culture and society.

The Spirit-Empowered Life of God's Family: Translation and Literary Design of Ephesians 5:21-6:9

²¹ submitting to one another in reverence of the Messiah,
²² **wives** to their own husbands
as to the Lord
²³ because the husband is the head of the wife
as the Messiah is head of the church,
the deliverer of the body.
²⁴ But as the church submits to the Messiah,
so also wives **[submit]** to their husbands in every way.
²⁵ **Husbands**, be loving your wives,
as the Messiah loves the church
and gave himself on her behalf,
²⁶ so that he could set her apart
having purified
by washing of water
with a word,
²⁷ so he could present the church to himself
glorious,
having no stain
or wrinkle
or any such thing
but that she would be set apart

Ephesians 5:21-6:9. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ephesians (2019).

The Greco-Roman Household Code



The Household Hierarchy. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ephesians (2019).

Household code instructions were always addressed to the man alone, who ruled over his household that consisted of women, children, and slaves who were “by nature” inferior.

“Seeing then that the state is made up of households, before speaking of the state we must speak of the management of the household. The parts of household management correspond to the persons who compose the household, and a complete household consists of slaves and freemen. Now we should begin by examining everything in its fewest possible elements; and the first and fewest possible parts of a family are master and slave, husband and wife, father and children.”

Aristotle (350 B.C.E.). *Politics*. 1:3

“Of household management we have seen that there are three parts: one is the rule of a master over slaves, which has been discussed already, another of a father, and the third of a husband. A husband and father, we saw, rules over wife and children, both free, but the rule differs; the rule over his children being royal, and the rule over his wife is based on natural constitution. For although there may be exceptions to the order of nature, the male is by nature fitter for command than the female, just as the elder and full-grown is superior to the younger and more immature.”

Aristotle (350 B.C.E.). *Politics*. 1:12

“The woman ... is in all things inferior to the man. Let her accordingly be obedient, not for her humiliation, but that she may be directed; for God has given authority to the man.”

Josephus, Flavius (2021). [Against Apion \(Book II\)](#). Alpha Edition. 24.

Paul's Reimagined Household Code

Paul's innovation is to adopt this cultural form of the household code but entirely reshape the foundation on which it rests: the assumed superiority of the patriarch. Instead, he places the risen Messiah in that position, which enables him to transform the code in two noticeable ways.

First, he addresses the traditionally subordinate parties (wives, children, slaves) as dignified moral agents who are not inferior but active participants in a household of the Messiah. This is outstanding in ancient household codes.

"Contemporary household codes were given for the benefit of patriarchs in that they were advised in how to manage or control their households—wives included—for their own benefit and for a stable society. In contrast to this, Paul addresses wives directly, exhorting them to participate fully and willingly in the New Humanity. He subverts the contemporary notion that the ordering of the household should be for the benefit of the patriarch or for those in power when he sets in parallel the "headship" of the husband in relation to his wife and that of Christ in relation to the church (5:23). The headship of Christ is characterized by his providing salvation for the church, recalling Christ's giving himself to death for the salvation of the church. This is the kind of "headship" Paul has in mind, so that those in subordinate positions in the New Humanity do not exist for the comfort of those at the top. Rather, those who have authority or power are to use it for the good, protection, and nurture of those subordinate to them."

Gombis, Timothy G. (2005). "A Radical New Humanity: The Function of the *Haustafel* in Ephesians." *JETS*, Vol. 48/2 (June). 317-330.

Paul's address to the patriarch in all three roles is a radical undermining of his inherent male authority. Instead, he becomes an agent of the Messiah's dignifying love to each group in his household.

We know that Paul cared about how the Christian household appeared to their Greek and Roman neighbors and that misbehavior could harm the reputation of the entire movement.

- 1 Timothy 6:1: Paul urges Christian slaves to honor their masters, "so that the name of God and our teaching might not be blasphemed."
- Titus 2:3-8: Paul urges older women to be exemplary matriarchs in the household, "so that the word of God will not be dishonored" (Titus 2:5), and so that "those hostile to us won't have anything bad to say about us" (Titus 2:8).

"The reminder of the links between discussion of the household and discussion of the state in the Greco-Roman world, whereby the household was viewed as the foundation of the state, is extremely significant for interpretation of the early Christian use of household codes. It reveals that proper household management was generally regarded as a matter of crucial social and political concern and that any upsetting of the traditional hierarchical order of the household could be considered a potential threat to the order of society as a whole ... In Greco-Roman culture, wives, children, and slaves were expected to accept the religion of the male head of the household (called the "paterfamilias"), and so religious groups that attracted women and slaves were particularly seen as potentially subversive of societal stability. Writers in Greco-Roman society singled out the cults of Dionysus and Isis, which attracted women devotees, and also Judaism, since Jewish slaves rejected the worship of their Roman masters' gods ... As Christianity spread in the Roman world and women and slaves converted to this new religion, it too became the object of similar

suspicion and criticism. Social tensions between Christians and the rest of society, as well as tensions within the early Christian movement, need, therefore, to be given their due in any account of the emergence of Christian household codes. It may well have been external factors, the need to respond to accusations from outsiders and to set standards in line with common notions of propriety, as much as internal ones, the need to respond to enthusiastic demands for freedom on the part of believers, that led Christians to take up the household code.”

Lincoln, Andrew T. (1990). “Ephesians.” [Word Biblical Commentary, Vol. 42](#). Thomas Nelson Inc. 358.

Wife Yields Voluntarily to Her Husband

Paul uses head (κεφαλή) here as a metaphor for source, which in a Greco-Roman culture was a socio-economic reality. The man in his 20s or 30s and/or his parents would arrange a marriage to a young, teenage woman, and he would become her provider so that his household and family could reshape her identity. Just as the head provides food, water, and air to the body, so the husband is the provider for his wife.

In [Ephesians 5:22](#), Paul explicitly defines what he means by head.

If Paul was using the metaphor “head” to primarily mean authority, this was his chance to do so, but instead he defines head in parallel to savior.

“This final clause (‘he being the savior’) is added to interpret the special sense in which Christ is here called the ‘head of the church.’ It is the function of the head to plan the safety of the body, to secure it from danger and to provide for its welfare. In the highest sense this function is fulfilled by Christ for the church and in symbolic sense it is fulfilled by the husband for the wife.”

Robinson, J. Armitage (1904). [St. Paul's Epistle to the Ephesians](#). Macmillan. 124.

“The place of the final phrase (‘he being the savior’) is called ‘apposition,’ the placing of a word or phrase beside another so that the second explains the first. The fact that Paul has modeled all three phrases after one another makes it clear, that Paul places ‘savior’ in apposition to ‘head’ to show that he intends ‘head’ to be understood as equivalent in meaning to ‘savior.’ If Paul intended to convey ‘head’ in the sense of authority, he would have said ‘he being the authority of body’ ... but his following description of Christ’s relationship to his body states nothing about authority, but recounts how Christ loved and gave himself for the church, to make her holy, to purify her, to feed and care for her. These are the actions of a savior, the source of life and nourishment of his body, the church. Paul calls the husband to imitate Christ’s actions in relation to his wife, not to assume authority over her.”

Payne, Philip Barton (2009). [Man and Woman, One in Christ: An Exegetical and Theological Study of Paul's Letters](#). Zondervan Academic. 283-284.

Paul’s description of the Messiah’s actions toward the body depicts Jesus as taking up the domestic duties that were typically assigned to women in the Greco-Roman household.

Husbands Called To Submit Themselves Through Self-Giving Love

Husbands are to imitate Christ’s role as head, source of the church, provider, and caretaker of slaves (washing, nursing). Christ is described with female duties, and therefore so is the husband. The wife is the

husband's body (wife is metaphorically a male body), a concept built on Genesis 2 (wife and husband become one flesh).

"This instruction to the husband/patriarch is completely at odds with contemporary household codes ... First, husbands are commanded to 'love' their wives, a command that appears in no other contemporary household code ... which focus on the proper ordering of household units by the patriarch for his own comfort and ease. Second, husbands are not to dominate their subordinate wives, but their love is to imitate the self-sacrificial love of Christ. Paul directly confronts the system of domination in the wider culture ... where the great authority that is invested in patriarchs over their entire households was often exercised with conniving manipulation. Husbands are to resist the temptation to operate according to the Old Humanity, and not to take advantage of their position as the head, but rather to use the power of their position for the sake of their wives."

Gombis, Timothy G. (2005). "A Radical New Humanity: The Function of the *Haustafel* in Ephesians." *JETS*, Vol. 48/2 (June). 327.

List of Obligations for a Husband to His Wife

The list of obligations that the husband has toward his wife in 5:29 and the actions of the Messiah for the church are rich in double meaning.

- Ephesians 5:27: "Washing" and "having no stain or wrinkle" are metaphors from clothes-washing, stain-spotting, and ironing.
- Ephesians 5:29: "To nourish" (Greek: *ἐκτρέφειν*) is used here of providing food and care, while in Ephesians 6:4, it refers to raising children.
- Ephesians 5:29: "To cherish" (Greek: *θάλπειν*), literally "to make warm." This primarily refers to what a mother provides for her children.

"Christ's love is illustrated by the sanctification of the church, which is described in terms of domestic chores normally performed by women: giving a bath, providing clothing, doing laundry (including spot removal and ironing). Through analogy and metaphor, Paul has told the husband to follow Christ by serving his wife's needs ... The Greco-Roman distinctions between males working and providing in the high-status public sphere (rural, forensic, political) and females working and providing in the low-status domestic sphere are broken down, as Paul unmistakably assigns intimate domestic service to both Christ and to the husband."

Westfall, Cynthia Long (2016). [*Paul and Gender: Reclaiming the Apostle's Vision for Men and Women in Christ*](#). Baker Academic. 94.

The image Paul draws from the word head meaning "source" aligns with his quotation of Genesis 2:24. In Ephesians 5:28-30, the wife is the husband's body, so what he does for her, he does to himself because she is "him" and he is "her" by virtue of their "body-head" relationship.

"'Each of you should love his wife as himself' (Eph. 5:33). According to Paul's argument, this means that a husband should treat his wife as he treats himself as a man. It is the Golden Rule in gender relationships ... This becomes the basis of one of his most powerful illustrations: the church is Christ's body, which derives its life and identity from him (Eph. 4:15-16; Col. 2:19), [and] shares in his high position and authority (

Eph. 1:20 and 2:5-6) ... As his body, believers are completely identified with Christ and his human status as co-heirs with him (Rom. 8:17). The analogy between Christ and the husband should lead men to share authority, status, power, and bring freedom that is comparable to what their head, Jesus Christ, has provided for them and intends for the rest of his body.”

Westfall, Cynthia Long (2016). [*Paul and Gender: Reclaiming the Apostle's Vision for Men and Women in Christ*](#). Baker Academic. 95.

Reflection Question

What does Paul include in his household code (Ephesians 5:21-6:9) that would stand out from the ancient culture? What seems radical about his language?